Who Represents the Destination, and What Do They Evaluate? Social-Media Posts about Qingdao

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Abstract. Social-media posts are often read as direct proxies for tourists' destination image. Treating posts as produced discourse rather than static cognitive images, we examine how institutional accounts and individual creators portray a single destination, Qingdao. Cleaning reduced 11,599 Qingdao tourism-related posts from four platforms to 10,178 destination-relevant posts. In a pilot of 100 posts (476 segments), practical trip-planning information (58% of segments) outweighed affective and sensory expression (30%). Core attractions were judged overwhelmingly favourably (155 of 166 evaluations), whereas operational aspects—price, service, accessibility, and crowding—were evenly divided (20 vs. 19).

Keywords: destination image · user-generated content · content creators · content analysis.

1 Background

Destination image is the cumulative beliefs and impressions a person holds about a place and cannot be reduced to simple aggregate content frequencies [5]. Social-media posts supply material for image formation [2] and can be coded for cognitive and affective attributes [1], but an online post is not equivalent to the internal cognitive image a visitor holds. Studies contrasting official marketing with tourist-generated content have mostly measured thematic presence through word frequencies [4]. Less is known about what a post does, which attributes it evaluates, and how creator identity shapes both.

2 Purpose

We compare how institutional accounts and individual creators represent Qingdao: their communicative strategies, the resources and attributes they evaluate, and how these co-occur within text segments. We hypothesize that, even when depicting identical destination resources, institutional posts consistently lean toward uncritical, promotional representation, whereas individual creators temper generally positive accounts with pragmatic caveats, critiques, or advice.

3 Method

We employ theory-driven structured content analysis [3]. Before coding, each post's text is divided into segments that each convey one self-contained point, using embedding-based semantic segmentation (Qwen3-Embedding-8B) constrained by fixed boundary

rules; coders do not alter segment boundaries. Each segment is coded for rhetorical strategy, target destination resource, evaluative attribute, and the valence and intensity of the evaluation. Account metadata are coded separately, and creator grouping criteria were fixed before any group comparison. A relevance classifier trained on 1,300 manually labelled posts screened the 11,599 Qingdao tourism-related posts collected from four platforms and retained 10,178 as destination-relevant. Two trained coders coded the pilot sample independently (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.82$ for evaluative direction) and resolved discrepancies by discussion.

4 Results to Date

What posts do. The pilot covers 100 randomly sampled posts (476 segments). Practical information (itineraries, pricing, how-to advice) appears in 58% of segments, sensory or emotional rendering in 30%, background knowledge in 11%, and calls for interaction in 3%. Approximately half of the posts convey explicit recommendations.

What posts judge. The coders agreed on both attribute and valence for 216 evaluations. Core attraction quality, activities, and destination atmosphere accounted for 166 evaluations (155 favourable vs. 10 unfavourable). Conversely, operational factors—price, service, facilities, accessibility, crowding, and management—accounted for 44 evaluations, with sentiment evenly split (20 favourable vs. 19 unfavourable).

5 Significance

Favourable evaluations attach mostly to endowed assets, whereas complaints concentrate on manageable operational touchpoints; the actionable signal for destination marketing organizations (DMOs) thus lies in roughly one-fifth of evaluations, which aggregate sentiment scores obscure. Speaking to the theme *Shaping Tourism Technology: Hype, Human Centricity and ROI*, models handle the high-volume steps of relevance filtering and segmentation, while human coders make the interpretive judgements. Social-listening tools that report evaluations by attribute and creator type, rather than as one sentiment score, would show DMOs where operational investment pays off.

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